

The Safavids

In 1501, a 14-year-old boy called Ismail seized control of Persia (modern-day Iran). Over the next 200 years, the Safavid Dynasty he founded ruled over one of the greatest empires to emerge from the region. At its height, the Safavid Empire controlled large parts of Turkey, the Caucasus region between Asia and Europe, and parts of western Asia.

The Safavids were followers of a branch of Islam called Shia. This set them at odds with the followers of other branches of Islam, most notably the Sunni rulers of the Ottoman Empire, their rivals in the region. Rivalry between the two empires led to a series of wars.

The Safavid Empire was located along the Silk Road, the trade route that connected the Far East and Europe. The empire developed busy ports and markets and grew rich by charging foreign traders to use them.

Art and architecture flourished under Safavid rule. The shahs (kings) ordered the building of grand cities,

with large mosques covered in calligraphy and multi-colored tiles. Craftworkers and artists produced fine metalwork, ceramics, and textiles, which were in great demand in markets across Asia and Europe.

The empire reached its peak under Shah Abbas I, but began declining after his death in 1629. A century later, in 1736, Shah Tahmasp II was deposed by one of his military commanders and the dynasty's rule came to an end.



▲ SHAH ABBAS I

After its formation, the Safavid Empire was frequently at war. The reign of the fifth shah, Abbas I, brought stability. He set up a permanent army, reclaimed lands lost in previous wars, encouraged trade, and welcomed foreigners into his court.

WARS WITH THE OTTOMANS

1532–1555

A land dispute leads to war between the Ottomans and the Safavids. The Ottomans emerge as victors, and gain large parts of western Asia.

1578–1590

The Safavids are in chaos after the death of the shah. Taking advantage, the Ottomans attack and capture Safavid territories in the Caucasus.

1603–1618

Led by Shah Abbas I, the Safavids attack and regain territories in the Caucasus and western Iran that had been lost to the Ottomans.

1623–1639

In the final war between the two empires, the Ottomans gain complete control over the region now known as Iraq.

SHAH MOSQUE ►

In 1590, Abbas I moved the capital of his empire to the city of Isfahan. The new capital was rebuilt and filled with buildings that displayed the empire's wealth. At its center was the beautifully tiled Masjid-e-shah, or Shah Mosque, which was the tallest building in the city.

Mosaics of colored tiles

